united in rebuffing Khrushchev's ultimatum, though there remained differing perspectives within the Western alliance on how diplomacy with the Soviets should be pursued. Notwithstanding his frustration at the lack of interest in addressing the status of Berlin, Khrushchev backed away from his deadline. When Kennedy became president, however, it was not long before he reissued his threat.

Dean Rusk once admitted that he lost sleep over Berlin. The future of the city presented Western diplomacy with huge challenges. And from the outset of his presidency, John F. Kennedy recognised its crucial importance. If West Berlin fell, US foreign policy would be in ruins. Article Five of the NATO Treaty stated, 'An attack upon one is an attack upon all.' If the US failed to act, the foundations of NATO would have been shattered.

There was also a very personal dimension to the problem facing JFK. In the eyes of the government in Bonn, West German security rested on Washington's willingness to use nuclear weapons against the USSR in response to Soviet aggression. Kennedy recognised that West Berlin was militarily indefensible (though in July 1961 he publicly observed that Bastogne and Stalingrad had been militarily indefensible).[7] If the Soviets or East Germans used force, Kennedy could quickly face the decision whether to use nuclear weapons or abandon two and a half million West Berliners. To use nuclear weapons against the USSR would invite Soviet nuclear attacks against the United States.

Kennedy's choices were further constrained by US nuclear planning. The Single Integrated Operational Plan, introduced in 1961, contained no provision for selective or graduated attacks. US war planners and the Joint Chiefs of Staff intended a massive spasm launch. If the Soviets seized West Berlin by force, the President would face the choice of 'holocaust or humiliation'. Accordingly, and in the face of opposition from the military, Defense Secretary McNamara sought to develop choices for the president. SIOP-63 (introduced on 1 August 1962) contained five options, though McNamara later stated that 'we insisted on a withholding and retargeting capability. We knew (but didn't tell the military) that we would never use the SIOP plans as they were formulated.'[8]